

amnesty.ca

Meta's plan to power Alberta data centre with fossil fuels is a disaster for future generations and the environment

Hilary Homes

3–4 minutes

Reacting to Meta's plan to power a one-gigawatt AI data centre in Alberta with energy from a yet-to-be-built liquefied 'natural' gas (LNG) plant, Ketty Nivyabandi, Secretary General of Amnesty International Canada's English-speaking section, said: "Burning fossil fuels to meet our existing energy needs spells devastation on its own. Expanding dirty gas production to meet the tech sector's skyrocketing demands amounts to a catastrophic attack on the rights of young people and future generations to a healthy environment. This must not be allowed to pass."

According to [a Meta news release published on Wednesday](#), the California-based social media giant is breaking ground on its first Canadian data centre, in Sturgeon County, Alberta, north of Edmonton. Meta says it will work with a consortium of energy companies, along with Alberta's non-profit power grid operator, to build a new gas plant to power the data centre, which will run on a

staggering one gigawatt (1,000 megawatts) of electricity.

For comparison, electricity demand in Calgary — a city with a population of approximately 1.6 million people — [averaged about 1.24 gigawatts per day in 2025](#).

Background

This summer, Amnesty International unequivocally condemned Canada's decisions to: roll back its climate emissions targets; and endorse the planning of [a new oil pipeline from the oil patch in Alberta to the British Columbia coast](#) while simultaneously pushing LNG expansion.

The construction of new fossil-fuel infrastructure jeopardizes Canada's obligations under the 2015 Paris Agreement and [puts the health of two billion people at risk](#). Meanwhile, Canada recently voted in favour of [a new UN climate accountability resolution](#) recognizing that states are legally bound to limit dangerous climate heating and protect communities.

The rapid expansion of generative AI and the construction of data centres globally raise a host of human rights and environmental concerns, including those posed by the burning of fossil fuels to meet rising electricity demands. In May, Amnesty International [released a report](#) documenting how the large-scale data-scraping used to develop AI platforms violates people's right to privacy and threatens to perpetuate negative stereotypes and biases against historically marginalized groups of people.

The report also shines a light on the massive strain new AI data centres impose on energy and water resources around the

locations where they are built. Unsurprisingly, the risks and harms are most felt by historically marginalized people, including Black, Indigenous, and racialized communities.

Nivyabandi noted Thursday that any large-scale construction proposals — AI-related or not — must respect Indigenous Nations' right to free, prior and informed consent (FPIC) over development projects that affect their territories. The right to FPIC is enshrined in the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples.

“Industrial development that tramples Indigenous rights, hogs clean water, and makes the planet unliveable is not progress,” said Nivyabandi. “Real progress liberates people to live safer, healthier lives, respects their identities, and upholds their dignity as human beings — no matter who they are or where they live.”